

3.2.4 2D Islam

Students are required to study those aspects of the religious beliefs, teachings, values and practices of Islam specified below and the different ways in which these are expressed in the lives of individuals, communities and societies.

They should develop a knowledge and critical understanding of:

- the specified material
- how the texts specified for study are interpreted and applied
- the influence of beliefs and teachings on individuals, communities and societies
- the causes, meanings and significance of similarities and differences in religious thought belief and practice within Islam
- approaches to the study of religion and belief.

They should be able to analyse and evaluate issues arising from the topics studied, and the views and arguments of the scholars prescribed for study.

Questions may be set that span more than one topic.

Students may study any version of the specified texts, but should be aware of issues related to translation where relevant. Quotations will not be used in questions.

Students should be able to use specialist language and terminology appropriately.

Exam questions will show a translation for any non-English terms (except for names of people, texts and schools of thought). However students are expected to recognise and understand the following technical terms: Tawhid, Barzakh, Al-Qadr, Jihad.

Section A: Islam

Sources of wisdom and authority

- The Qur'an: its nature and authority; Muslim beliefs about the revelation and compilation of the Qur'an; the importance of the Arabic text and how this is reflected in the treatment and use of the Qur'an in worship and in everyday life; translation as interpretation and the importance of trustworthy interpretation of the Qur'an.
- The Prophet: the status of Muhammad as Khatam an-Nabiyyin (seal of the Prophets) and his significance for Muslims today; different views about the nature and value of hadiths as sources of knowledge of the sayings and actions of Muhammad.
- Imams: the authority of the Imams in Shi'a Islam.

God

- Tawhid: the Oneness of God; God as transcendent and indescribable, the omnipotent creator and controller of all things; teaching about God in the Throne verse: 2:255.
- Personal aspects of God: The significance of 'The Merciful' and 'The Compassionate' as Names of God; different Muslim views about how anthropomorphic descriptions of God in the Qur'an should be interpreted. Ashari, Hanbali and Mutazili views, with particular reference to the hand of God and the face of God.
- Aspects of the Sufi concept of God: God as incomparable and unknowable in Himself ; Creation as emanation and God as immanent; the soul as one with God; Sufi understandings of the teaching about God in the verse of Light: 24:35.

Self, death and afterlife

- Muslim views about the purpose of life as being to worship God and a moral test; the concept of worship and consideration of the view that, for Muslims, this life is only important as a preparation for the life to come.
- Al-Qadr: different understandings of the relationship between divine control, human freedom and responsibility. Mutazili and Ashari perspectives and the Shi'a concept of Bada.
- Akhirah (afterlife): the concept of soul; beliefs about Barzakh, judgement heaven and hell including different understandings of resurrection and of the descriptions of heaven and hell in the Qur'an including 47:15.

Good conduct and key moral principles

- Good conduct: the importance of good moral conduct in Islam including reference to the duty of obedience to God and the Prophet and to the greater jihad; the role of personal freedom and judgement in the Shari'ah law, with reference to the five-fold classification of actions.
- Sanctity of life: the concept of the sanctity of life and its application to issues concerning the embryo and the unborn child; lesser jihad as a duty of the Ummah and how it applied to warfare at the time of the Prophet; debates about its application today, including to the use of weapons of mass destruction and terrorism.
- Stewardship: the role of the Ummah as Khalifah (stewards) and their responsibilities towards the environment and to animal life; how changing understandings of the impact of human activities on the world change Muslim understandings of their responsibilities.

Expressions of religious identity

- The concept of Muslim: the similarities and differences between Shi'a and Sunni views about what it means to be a Muslim.
- The Pillars of Islam: the concept of pillar and purpose of the five pillars of Islam; Salah: differences in Sunni and Shi'a practices; the importance of the outward actions of prayer and the underlying intentions and state of mind; the importance of daily and Jumma prayers; Hajj: developments in the practice of Hajj in the 20th century and the significance and importance of Hajj today.
- The mosque: the changing role of the mosque in the community, with particular reference to the history and developing work of the London Central Mosque.

Islam, gender and sexuality

Historical and social factors that have influenced developments in Muslim thinking about these issues including: encounter with western values and lifestyles as part of the British Empire and through later immigration into Britain; the changing roles of men and women in society outside of religion; the rights given to women by secular governments.

Developments in Muslim thought, including feminist approaches:

- The veil seen as a barrier to achievement in Qasim Amin's work in 1899 and other Muslim views on this issue.
- Debates about the role and status of women in Islam with particular reference to the interpretation of 4:34 and the views of Amina Wadud.
- Contemporary Muslim views about celibacy, marriage, homosexuality and transgender issues.

Islam and science

How and why science has influenced Islam and how Islam has responded, with particular reference to: science's emphasis on evidence and reason; specific scientific discoveries; science as a stimulus to Muslim ethical thinking.

Developments in Muslim thought:

- How science has challenged Muslim belief and different Muslim responses to Darwin's theory of evolution and the Big Bang theory.
- The importance of science in early Muslim thought: science as a duty required by the Qur'an. The belief that the Qur'an revealed what science later confirmed with reference to the work of Maurice Bucaille.
- Different Muslim responses to ethical issues raised by science: genetic engineering.

Islam and the challenge of secularisation

This topic may be studied with exclusive reference to the British context.

Challenges of secularisation including: the replacement of religion as the source of truth and moral values; relegation of religion to the personal sphere; the rise of militant atheism: the view that religion is irrational.

Developments in Muslim thought:

- Responses to materialistic secular values: the value of wealth and possessions and the debate about capital punishment; comparison of the significant ideas of Tariq Ramadan and Sheikh Ahmad Ash-Sharabasi concerning capital punishment.
- Emphasis on the preservation of Muslim identity with reference to dress and diet, prayer places of worship, and the self-reliance of the Muslim community; different attitudes to democracy and to involvement in the democratic process.
- Emphasis on the social relevance of Islam, liberationist approaches supporting the poor and defending the oppressed.

Islam, migration and religious pluralism

How migration has created multicultural societies which include Islam, with particular reference to migration by Muslims into the United Kingdom from the 1950s onwards; the diversity within the Muslim community in Britain; freedom of religion as a human right in European law and religious pluralism as a feature of modern secular states; the influence of this context on Muslim thought.

Developments in Muslim thought:

- Emphasis on exclusivism; its basis in the Qur'an, 3:85; attitudes within Islam to minority Muslim groups.
- Inclusivism and its basis in the Qur'an with reference to both Abrahamic and non-Abrahamic faiths; the debate about whether good deeds without faith in God or Islam are rewarded by God.
- Muslim responses to issues of freedom of religious expression in society.

Section B: Dialogues

This section of the specification is focused on the connections between various elements of the course and requires students to develop breadth and depth in their understanding of the connections between the knowledge, understanding and skills set out in the specification. There are two areas for study, firstly the dialogue between Islam and philosophy: how developments in belief have, over time, influenced and been influenced by philosophical studies of religion, secondly the dialogue between Islam and ethics: how developments in belief have influenced and been influenced by ethical studies.

Students will be required to demonstrate a critical awareness of these connections and to analyse their nature.

The dialogue between Islam and philosophy

Beliefs and teachings about:

- God
- self, death and afterlife
- sources of wisdom and authority
- religious experience
- the relationship between scientific and religious discourses
- the truth claims of other religions
- miracles.

The following issues, and the impact of the discussion on religious belief past and present, should be considered:

- How far the belief is reasonable – that is based on reason and/or consistent with reason.
- How meaningful the statements of faith are, and for whom.
- How coherent the beliefs are, and how consistent with other beliefs within the belief system.
- The relevance of philosophical enquiry for religious faith, with particular reference to the debate about the nature of faith as ‘belief in’ or ‘belief that’.

Two unstructured questions will be set. Students must answer one.

The dialogue between Islam and ethics

- Muslim responses to the following approaches to moral decision making in the light of key Muslim moral principles:
 - deontological, with reference to Kant
 - teleological and consequential, with reference to Bentham
 - character based, with reference to virtue ethics.
- How far Muslim ethics can be considered to be deontological, teleological, consequential, or character based.
- Muslim response to: the issues of human life and death and issues of animal life and death prescribed for study; theft and lying; marriage; homosexuality and transgender issues; genetic engineering including.
- Muslim responses to issues surrounding wealth, tolerance and freedom of religious expression.
- Muslim understandings of free will and moral responsibility, and the value of conscience in Muslim moral decision-making.

The impact of other ethical perspectives and ethical studies on Muslim views about these issues, both past and present. This may include challenges to and support for Muslim views; compatibility of Muslim views with those of other ethical perspectives; the relative strengths and weaknesses of

Muslim perspectives and the other ethical perspectives studied on these issues; the implications of criticisms of Muslim ethical teaching for the religion as a whole and its sources of authority.

Two unstructured questions will be set. Students must answer one.